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[ESSAY | GS PAPER I – INDIAN SOCIETY | GS PAPER II – GOVERNANCE | GS PAPER III – INTERNAL SECURITY]
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Grey Hounds



Grey Hounds is an elite counter-insurgency force established to combat Left-Wing Extremism through specialized jungle warfare, intelligence and rapid operations. The article examines its evolution, organizational structure, operational role and contribution to India's internal security framework.

Grey Hounds

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Essay

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The Grey Hounds was born out of a realisation that conventional policing was proving inadequate against the growing influence and armed strength of Maoists. The then Andhra Pradesh Government wanted a force that could take the fight into forests and match the insurgents on their own terrain.

In 1989, IPS officer K.S. Vyas created Greyhounds to combat the Maoist insurgency. Within a few years, the striking force had evolved into one of the country's most specialised counter-insurgency units, operating deep inside forests and developing tactics specifically suited to jungle warfare. It also became a model for other states seeking to create specialised units to fight insurgency in different terrain.

- Odisha – Special Operation Group
- Maharashtra – C-60
- West Bengal – Counter-Insurgency Force
- Chhattisgarh – District Reserve Guard

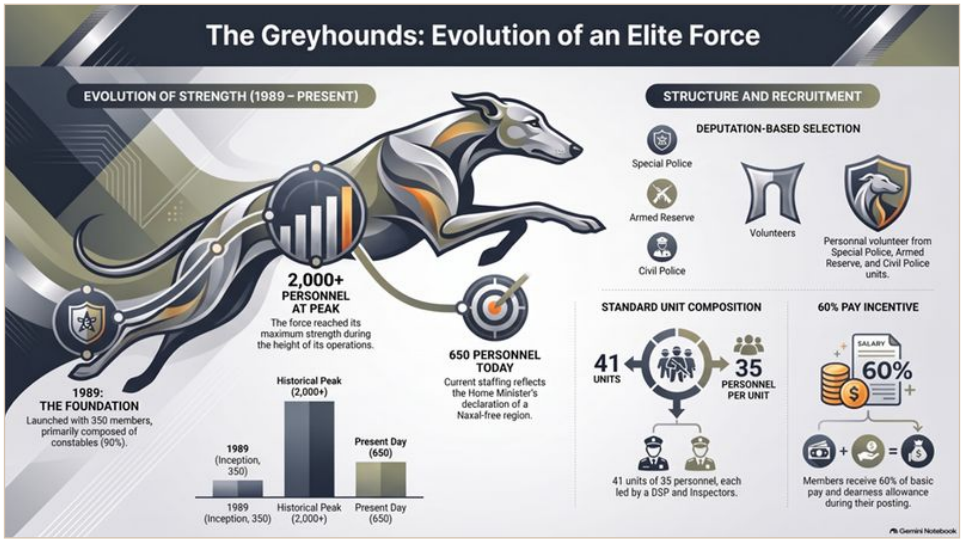
Even the CRPF's elite Commando Battalion for Resolute Action (COBRA) drew from the Greyhounds model.



When DIG Vyas took charge on June 15, 1989, the Greyhounds was a 350-member force, with nearly 90% of its personnel being constables. Vyas headed the unit until March 30, 1990. Over the years, its strength grew to over 2,000 at its peak. Today, following Union Home Minister Amit Shah's declaration in May that the country was Naxal-free, the force has 650 personnel, an officer says.

In the erstwhile Andhra Pradesh, the Greyhounds had 41 units, each comprising 35 personnel including a DSP, an inspector and three sub-inspectors. There is no separate recruitment for the force. It is a deputation-based unit, with personnel volunteering from the Special Police, Armed Reserve and Civil Police.

Those seeking a posting with the Greyhounds are screened for physical fitness, mental resilience and the determination required for the job. Personnel deputed to the force receive 60% of their basic pay and dearness allowance for the duration of their posting.



Cost of the war

The Greyhounds carried out numerous operations over the years, neutralising hundreds of rebels across Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. There were also instances when its teams crossed into neighbouring Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh to strike targets operating from across State borders.

But the striking force had another backbone: intelligence. At the heart of the Greyhounds' success was the Special Intelligence Branch (SIB), another specialised unit that emerged alongside the force to track the movement and activities of the rebels.

Since its inception, the Greyhounds has neutralised 693 rebels in undivided Andhra Pradesh and seized 1,250 firearms, Kumar says. Following the formation of Telangana on June 2, 2014, the force has killed 92 Naxals and recovered 360 weapons, he adds.

But the fight against the Red Army came at a heavy cost. The Greyhounds lost over 60 men over the years, including six after the formation of Telangana.

One of its biggest setbacks came on June 29, 2008, when Maoists ambushed a team on the Balimela reservoir in Odisha, killing 37 people, including 32 commandos.

The Greyhounds team had crossed into Odisha in pursuit of Maoists who had taken shelter there. Unable to locate them, the commandos were returning when Maoists, who had laid an ambush around the reservoir, opened fire on their boat.

The attack sank the boat and became one of the darkest chapters in the force's history.

